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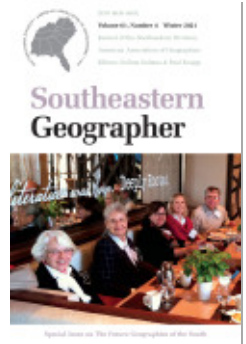
POWER and the Future of Appalachia: Discursive Framings of an Economic Transition

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POWER and the Future of Appalachia: Discursive Framings of an Economic Transition

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HIGHLIGHTS

- The coal economy in Central Appalachia is in steep decline.
- Institutions and actors divergently frame a discourse about the region's "economic transition."
- Different discursive frames evidence an ideological struggle over the future of the region.
- A federal program for economic transition measures job and business creation.
- Alternative framings center improving quality of life.

ABSTRACT: *As coal-mining employment and production levels reach historic low levels in the Appalachian region, institutions and actors articulate divergent discourses of what futures may be possible for the Appalachian region. Using Ada Smith's (2016) notion of "Appalachian Futurism" as a point of departure (understanding how theorizations of the past structure and limit what is imaginable for the future), I analyze the ways that a federal grants program, the POWER Initiative, frames Appalachia's economic transition. Through analysis of program documents and investments, I identify how particular discourses of development lead to programmatic foci of interventions around "entrepreneurship" and "workforce development." I then look at an alternative framing of the discourse of economic transition: one that posits a development agenda focused on improving quality of life for communities, as opposed to job and business creation. Drawing on documents from the Highlander Research and Education Center and on a dozen interviews with economic development practitioners, I detail the ways institutions and actors frame and reframe discourses as part of ideological struggle. In the conclusion, I examine trends for the future development of the region and offer policy suggestions for a more just economic future in the coalfields.*

KEYWORDS: Coal, Development, Entrepreneurship, Just transition

INTRODUCTION

The coal industry in Appalachia has recently passed below all benchmarks for its lowest production and employment levels yet recorded (EIA 2019). Long considered the defining industry in Central Appalachia, a region often defined by the concentration of bituminous coalfields that span the mountainous plateau from northeast Tennessee to West Virginia (Moore 2005), coal mining increasingly appears to be an industry of the past for Appalachia. While extensive research has focused on the agrarian transformation that established industrial extraction in Appalachia (Stoll 2017, Billings and Blee 2000, Lewis 1998, Pudup 1995, Moore 1990, Eller 1982), few studies have as yet

focused on the more recent, albeit decades-in-the-making, industrial transformation beyond coal. This article joins a growing body of research that investigates the contours of Appalachia's contemporary (de)industrial transformation (Abraham 2017, Brown et al. 2016, Maggard 1994).

In the wake of the coal industry's decline, political actors, entities, and institutions offer various and at times conflicting proposals and visions for what revitalization, recovery, or redevelopment can and should offer the people in Appalachia. Community, non-profit, and governmental actors increasingly discuss divergent visions using the same language of "economic transition," yet differently framing a discourse of economic transition in order to make claims on the future of the region. The resulting proposals, visions, and imagined futures have material effect, structuring, guiding, and directing economic development, policy, and practice in the region.

Ada Smith refers to one approach to the material work of imagination as "Appalachian Futurism." In a region where the decline of the coal industry has brought high levels of unemployment and poverty to many already struggling people (the Appalachian coalfields being home to some of the highest poverty rates in the American South (Flippen 2017)), Smith stresses that a brighter future for Appalachia requires radically rethinking the past to reimagine what could be possible for the future. Invoking "Afrofuturism," Mark Dery's (1994) term for Black science fiction works such as those of Samuel Delaney, Smith urges a reckoning with the past, or "understanding how you came to be," in order to "visualize and enact a new Appalachia" (Smith 2016, 74).

Scholars, activists, and artists often use the term "Afrofuturism" to refer to works of cultural production (from music to visual arts to science fiction) that use the vantage of the future to analyze and critique anti-Black violence of the present or past and to envision prosperous Black futures (see Sites 2021, Holbert et al. 2020, Josephs 2013). Afrofuturism provides a framework and inspiration for Smith's call to critically re-examine representations of Appalachia's past in order to imagine new possibilities for the future.

Taking Ada Smith's formulation of Appalachian futurism as a point of departure, in this article I ask how different imagined possible futures structure and condition interventions that are setting regional economic trajectories for years to come.

One useful site from which to understand how discourses of transition shape Appalachian futures is a federal grant program dedicated to economically restructuring the Appalachian coalfields. This federal initiative, the POWER (Partnerships for Opportunity and Workforce and Economic Revitalization) Initiative, housed at the Appalachian Regional Commission (ARC) aims "to create a more vibrant economic future for coal-impacted communities" (ARC 2019a).

Examining how the POWER Initiative frames the current moment as an economic transition provides a unique sightline into the theories of change and assumed possible futures that govern current federal economic interventions in the Appalachian region. Thus far, these ideas and rationales have guided and bounded more than a quarter-billion-dollar investment intended to restructure the economy, with more investments to come. However, the limited scope of federal bureaucratic interventions, constrained politically in their mandate and technically in the limited tools and available funding,

perhaps obviously, does not necessarily encompass what community institutions or social movements in the coalfields imagine as desirable futures.

In the first part of this article, I trace how this federal grants program rationalizes its intervention. In the second section of this paper, I examine what I refer to as an “Appalachian futurist” framing of the economic transition, a framing that focuses on improving quality of life rather than growing jobs and businesses. I analyze this alternative framing as compared with programs and projects that are a product of an employment-focused framing. The understandings of history and theories of change embedded in these framings of economic transition are inherently political: implicitly and explicitly, each framing defines who is considered an agent of economic change, and for whom economies should function. These multiple discursive frames indicate the role of ideology and ideological struggle (Gramsci 2000, Hall 1996) in determining the future of the region.

With 2020 marking the closure of all mining operations in some Appalachian states¹ (e.g., Tennessee), plummeting coal employment and production figures, and multiplying bankruptcies (Legere and Litvak 2020) make the region one of the few existing test cases for post-fossil-fuel energy transition. A robust and growing literature on energy geographies studies the politics of energy production, energy distribution, and clean energy transition (Gavin Bridge and Gailing 2020, Baka and Vaishnav 2020, Knuth 2019, Calvert 2016, Huber 2015, Zimmerer 2011). However, unlike much of this literature, in this article I focus on what Gavin Bridge terms “destablisation and disassembly” of an energy system; not the emergence of new innovative structures, but “instead on the conditions of possibility that sustain durable structures over time and space, and the consequences for people and places when those conditions no longer hold” (Bridge 2018, 18). Appalachia increasingly is a place where the conditions to continue mining coal no longer hold, with severe implications for environmental justice (Bell 2013, Bullard 2008) concerns (e.g., toxic waste, abandoned mined lands, and lingering environmental risks and hazards) that remain as coal’s legacy.

METHODS

In this paper I use discourse analysis to examine how federal grant makers and community leaders represent the decline of coal in terms of an economic transition. Discourse analysis enables me to examine how ideas about Appalachia’s future shape economic development practice.

Discourse analysis examines semiotics and representation to consider the power relations therein, and enables an examination of the recursive relationship between representation and that which is represented (Hall 1997, Foucault 1971). Discourse analysis is also an important method of geographic qualitative analysis (for example, see Dittmer 2010, Lees 2004). Studies of economic development too have used discourse analysis to consider both development itself as a discourse and to understand the power relations produced through the deployment of development initiatives (Crush 1995). In this article, I leverage works from geography and analyses of development to consider discourses of post-coal futures in the Appalachian context.

I analyze five years of federal requests for funding proposals, federal guidelines for grant-seeking institutions, the initial 2015 Obama-era presidential directive that created the POWER program, 2016 congressional legislative language that funds the program, and grant reports from five years of funding to 293 projects, as of October 2020. I coded the grants-funded data and analyzed funding apportionment within the grants database. As a point of comparison, I examine the Highlander Education and Research Center's documentation of their Economic Transition Fellowship, operating between 2015 and 2017. Furthermore, I compare projects and proposals for Appalachian economic development that I encountered during fieldwork between 2019 and 2020, involving twelve semi-structured interviews conducted in person or on the phone with grant seekers, those implementing federal funds, and non-profit leaders and staff interested in Appalachian economic development, broadly defined. Together, the archival and interview data provide a robust image of ways that representations of Appalachia's transition have material effects on projects that are setting trajectories for future economies, from which I am able to draw some predictions about and suggestions for the future of the region.

DISCOURSES OF POWER

Public documents detailing the rationale and guidelines for the POWER Initiative implicitly theorize the roots of poverty in Appalachia as tied to a lack of market competition, and explicitly present solutions as bounded within stimulating employment and entrepreneurship (an often-used term to encompass financial support, training, or technical support for starting and growing businesses). These theories of development and rationales rely on notions of empowering individuals to be better-trained and better-capitalized individual actors in a free market.

Representing the program as a corrective to seemingly natural effects of uneven development arising from resource extraction, federal political personnel articulate a theory of change (an understanding of the past and how their intervention will stimulate a corrective to endemic poverty) that revolves around "diversifying" the economy. Here I present how the POWER Initiative, rather than engaging in an Appalachian futurist reimagination of what could be possible, is framed within the terms of neoclassical economics, offering an imagination of the future theorized in familiar terms: in the terms of neoliberal ideology (Brown 2019, 2015).

The POWER Initiative

In 2015, when then President Barack Obama launched the POWER Initiative, the funding was considered necessary because, as the announcement states, the "United States is undergoing a rapid energy transformation, particularly in the power sector" (Office of the President 2015, np). Discussing a transition to cleaner, safer, and economically efficient fuel sources, the Obama administration framed POWER as a tool to help dislocated workers and impacted communities bearing the burden of a transitioning economy.

The initial language detailed that, despite an interest in helping communities define their own "economic futures," projects that could be implemented encompassed only

four categories: training workers, “attracting” new employers, “creating” new jobs, and diversifying the economy (Office of the President 2015, np). Perhaps the broadest criterion was that of diversification, a concept that implies that the coal industry’s mono-economy had stifled competition and left many people with few skills, providing a rationale for the job-creation strategies put forward.

When POWER was congressionally funded through the 2016 budget, the Initiative became housed at ARC. Under ARC mandate, the POWER Initiative became solely focused on Appalachia. The ARC’s POWER Initiative program documents reworked the earlier categories, adding an additional area to make five funding priorities: workforce development (e.g., technical college training programs), entrepreneurship (or helping start and grow businesses), “developing industry clusters in communities” (often including incentives to attract new employers to come to a place), and substance abuse response (connecting job training and employment with addiction treatment and recovery). Fifth, a full third of the 2019 programs were earmarked for building broadband infrastructure, much more than in prior years (previously communities were directed toward EPA’s broadband planning funding) (ARC 2019b). Through these priorities, the ARC makes clear their understanding that not only do communities have the potential to remarket themselves (mapping their assets), but individuals, as workers and as entrepreneurs, have the personal potential to remake their own economic success: what is needed is the right economic “ecosystem,” a term used frequently throughout the five years of grant documents (ARC 2019b). Supporting that ecosystem includes attracting large corporations, but also increasingly a focus on infrastructure, such as broadband.

Entrepreneurship and workforce development

In my quantitative analysis of the funding the ARC provided to coal-producing counties between 2015 and 2019, nearly forty percent went to workforce development and training (\$47 million), and nearly twenty-five percent went to entrepreneurship development (\$29.5 million). The rest was distributed between investments for attracting or developing manufacturing facilities, addiction response (paired with job training), tourism infrastructure, broadband and other infrastructure investments, with a small amount towards research and planning.² These foci illustrate the outcomes of framing Appalachia’s problem as stifled economic growth from a lack of competition, and an implied logic that market competition has a snowball effect; that business success only requires jump-start grants and job seekers simply need training. This focus on entrepreneurship and workforce development comes from an ideological position, a neoliberal ideology that posits that if individual economic actors (generally assumed to be white men) take part in an ever more free market, those who work hard will succeed (Brown 2019, 2015).

Geographers have discussed neoliberal ideology in practice, broadly put, as variegated processes of government-assisted market rule (Peck et al. 2012), whereby privatization of public goods and services is justified through an ideology based upon theories of Friedrich Hayek and other free-market utopians (Hayek 2007). Neoliberal ideology leverages a logic of individualism, small government, and free-market rule to dismantle social welfare and public government programs, while generally in practice increasing

spending on security, prison, and military government elements and the gutting of social safety nets (Peck and Theodore 2019, Peck et al. 2018, 2010). The POWER Initiative thus far has been framed within this neoliberal ideology, assuming the individual entrepreneur or job seeker as the point of entry for economic intervention, and success measured in jobs and private gains (Hall et al. 2015).

JOB CREATION VERSUS QUALITY OF LIFE

Community institutions and non-profits, such as the historic Highlander Research and Education Center, have articulated alternative framings of a discourse of economic transition. In their framings, the economic transition is a process that needs public investment, support, speeding up, and one that has the potential to bring higher standards of living to people in the region. Framing economic development in terms of quality of life offers an Appalachian futurist frame of economic transition; one that theorizes Appalachia's past as full of vibrant life despite the manufactured poverty and pollution of the coal economy, while also envisioning a development regime that invests in community well-being, not market value.

Through an analysis of interviews with staff and leadership at regional non-profits and economic development agencies and the Highlander Center's economic transition program, I map two divergent framings of the economic transition: one focused on job growth, and one on quality of life. At times overlapping in the projects enacted, these frames are informed by different theories of change and articulate different goals for development.

Creating jobs

One interviewee³ that worked at a regional lending institution based in West Virginia articulated a clear imagined future for the Appalachian coalfields: as an outdoor recreation tourist economy. Interviewed in person in July of 2019, the interviewee provided economic development loans to help launch small-scale outdoor recreation equipment manufacturing. "The model is something like Asheville, [North Carolina,]" the lender explained, where outdoor amenities had drawn tourists and people moving for lifestyle choices, followed by small businesses to serve the niche recreation economies, ultimately creating small-scale recreation manufacturing economies that are now producing for national markets. For the coalfields, "The long-term goal is to create four-wheeler parts manufacturing hub," with loans to all-terrain vehicle (ATV) equipment and specialized parts manufacturing in emerging trail-riding towns.

Similarly, another recipient of POWER funding explained their vision for Appalachian futures rested fully on incentivizing clustering of advanced chemical manufacturing. With Charleston, West Virginia, already a national hub of the chemical industry, dubbed "the chemical valley," the interviewee (who worked for an economic development agency when I interviewed them in person in June of 2019) presented a future where more strategic funding for "entrepreneurial activity" and experimentation would draw more chemical companies to relocate in the valley, and in their technology park in particular, according to clustering theory.

Others explained a similar logic for a wood-products industry. Recipients of POWER funding interviewed over the phone in July 2019 indicated that a main problem in the forest-products industry was maintaining a large enough and stable enough worker base. Thus, more worker training programs, as well as incentives for wood-product manufacturing to relocate near other existing manufacturing sites should create the clustering effect as well.

Going beyond the discursive terrains of job creation, a non-profit executive in West Virginia I interviewed in person in June of 2019 explained a strategy for combining worker training and education with the incubation of new small businesses in food, agriculture, entertainment, and arts. The hope was that not only would these new businesses be able to thrive as start-ups in a newly entrepreneurial ecosystem, but that the trained workers would provide a ready-to-work labor force. However, the interviewee explained, "People need jobs... they also need more than that. They need quality of life." In this strategy, the small businesses grow jobs, but worker training improves quality of life, increased pay, educational attainment, while small businesses also offer what economically declining communities need to keep people from leaving: jobs, community-oriented entertainment, and access to good food.

Quality of life

A discursive framing of Appalachia's economic transition that focuses on improving community quality of life reverses the subject of development from that of the employer (who would provide jobs, investment, or capital to the community) to the resident of a community. This reversal is illustrative of an Appalachian futurist framing: centering a higher quality of life for all (a reimagination of what could be possible) by redefining the coal industry and coalfield Appalachia's uneven relationship to the rest of the country (Moore 1994) as having created the conditions that lowered people's quality of life (retheorizing how the present came to be).

As a discourse of development, this quality-of-life framing operates through the following logic: if places are desirable places to live, with clean air, water, access to good food, natural and cultural amenities, healthcare, employment, and many more factors that mark a high quality of life, then communities will, at least, maintain their populations, if not grow. In this framing, communities themselves drive economic activity and deserve high quality of life, irrespective of economic productivity. A quality-of-life discourse reframes development as a question of how to keep people (whether conceptualized as a tax base, consumers of products, or simply valued as community members) in place.

An instance of this discursive frame, the Highlander Research and Education Center, not a recipient of federal funding from POWER, has rearticulated the discourse of economic transition in terms that present the transition as a moment to create a more just economy and society. One of Highlander's programs between 2015 and 2017 was the Appalachian Transition Fellowship Program. In a document describing the fellowship (a stipend/training provided to between ten and twenty "emerging leaders"), Highlander described their vision for Appalachia and their program: "This transition offers the region a chance to focus on the well-being of its people and communities" (Highlander

Center 2017, 1). The document, while careful not to attack the coal industry, offers a retheorization of Appalachia's past as one where the coal industry failed to provide a high quality of life for many, prevented economies from continuing that supported ecological and human well-being, and left toxic and unhealthy legacies in its wake. The document frames the transition as an opportunity to create more sustainable and just economies. The fellowship program was intended to, as they say, "accelerate this transition by increasing the capacity of the region" (Highlander Center 2017, 1). Providing these fellowships to diverse, creative, and innovative leaders in the region, the historic center hoped to more swiftly create these new economies built around "solidarity" and "justice" for the people of the region.

Another articulation of this discursive frame came from community economic development staff in southwest Virginia: one interviewee, interviewed over the phone in November of 2020, explained that a major goal was to create hiking trails in coalfield communities. The goal was not simply to attract tourists (although a possible benefit), but to serve community members who had to travel for dozens of miles to reach the closest hiking trails, despite having mountains of forests in their backyards.

Other interviewees focused on small-scale agriculture and food systems. Rather than attempting to incubate food entrepreneurs as the POWER Initiative has done (see Todd 2018), some food- and farming-focused advocates articulated visions of supporting farming as a way to maintain livelihoods in rural communities. "We want a way to stay [in West Virginia]," a West Virginia community-development professional I interviewed in person in June of 2019, explained, saying that given the right measures of quality of life, "farming can provide that opportunity." Framing this economic transition around increasing quality of life, these agriculture advocates wanted to see farming and farmers supported as a way to keep young people in their communities, a route to provide fresh food for communities, and an occupation that people can build full lives around. Although overlapping with some POWER Initiative goals, the rationale and the goals of these food/farming projects contrast with those intended mostly to create jobs, business growth, and attract capital and employment.

PREDICTIONS AND SUGGESTIONS

In a moment of economic and political rupture, a reordering that is part of a global political economic restructuring, what Nancy Fraser has labeled a historic "interregnum" between the end of so-called "progressive" neoliberalism's hegemony and a new political economic order (Fraser 2019), differing accounts of Appalachia's possible futures signal that there will be a struggle of ideas before new political economic trajectories are set. In Stuart Hall's theorizations of representation and ideology, semiotics and representational work is always couched within politics, within ideological struggle, and there are no outsides to ideology (Hall 1996). The ways that different elements of state, civil society, and community institutions take up the discourse of an economic transition evidences the politics within Appalachian economic development projects and proposals. Politics – the activities that align power relations – always entail questions of resource distribution.

The neoliberal politics that have shaped the POWER Initiative, for instance, do not treat the coal industry's decline as a moment necessitating public infrastructure investment, government jobs programs, public assistance, or any number of responses oriented to a broadly conceived *public*. Rather, the program is largely framed and bounded within the need to stimulate private enterprise, even couching public investments like broadband within terms of private-sector support. Reframing an economic transition as a moment to improve quality of life offers a politics that treats communities as deserving well-being without economic justification; a politics that would structure an intervention at a broader notion of a public.

These various discourses of development provide some ground from which to predict trends for Appalachia's future, and perhaps even more upon which to offer suggestions of what could bring a more just future for the people living in this region.

PREDICTIONS: DEPOPULATION, TOURISM, AND FOREST CONSERVATION

There are at least three clear trends for coalfield Appalachia's future: depopulation, growing tourism economies, and expanding conservation landscapes. First, the amount of money invested in tourist economic development, from ATV trail economies to cultural amenity development, indicates growing demand for tourism infrastructure. My interviews show outdoor-recreation tourism is increasingly understood as a growing part of the post-coalfield economy.

Second, despite the best efforts of economic developers and investors, areas of the coalfields will continue to depopulate and become abandoned. Even if economic trends somewhat improve, young people already face very few opportunities for education and occupation. Furthermore, coalfield areas are home to some of the most elderly populations in Appalachia. As these populations pass on, the current trend indicates that a new generation will not replace those aging in place (Adams and Bleizeffer 2020). This trend has already had important impacts on economies such as tourism, where areas that were once high-population-density coal communities are now being recast as natural forested landscapes for ATV trail riding.

Third, following depopulation and industrial decline, conservation investors have identified the coalfields as bargain-value forests. Conservation, carbon offsets, and conservation easements are growing uses of these forest lands, as demonstrated with The Nature Conservancy's 2019 purchase of half-a-million acres of forests for their Cumberland Forest Project (The Nature Conservancy 2019). Also, accounting across Tennessee, West Virginia, and Virginia, the Appalachian coalfields are the third-largest concentration of forest carbon-offset projects registered with the California Air Resources Board as part of the state's carbon trading system, behind Alaska and California (California Air Resources Board 2019). Furthermore, the use of forest land for conservation and forest carbon offsets often combines with recreation and tourist purposes, many of those conserved lands publicly accessible through leases with state wildlife management agencies. The coalfields without coal, it seems, are increasingly being reimagined and rediscovered as novel wilderness.

SUGGESTIONS: ENVIRONMENTAL REMEDIATION AND RURAL INFRASTRUCTURE

Finally, I conclude here with a proposal that funding mine-land reclamation and investing in local infrastructure would be foundational for more just economies in Central Appalachia.

As with other geographies that house industrial waste, questions of environmental justice linger beyond the presence of industry (Vasudevan 2019). One instance is that amid the coalfield landscapes of industrial ruin (Vasudevan and Smith 2020, Brown 2018, Stoler 2008), thousands of abandoned strip mines (Abandoned Mine Lands [AML], left without clean up before regulation in 1977) litter the landscape, covering roughly 850,000 acres in the region (Dixon 2021). Reclaiming and making those sites safe for surrounding communities would cost an estimated \$21 billion and create at least 7,000 jobs in Central Appalachia from 2021–2030 (Boettner and Dixon 2021). Currently, AML reclamation moves slowly, and congressional plans for future reclamation have suggested funding at half the estimated necessary level. One way to support Appalachia's economic and ecologic transition to a more just future is through massive investment in reclaiming AML sites.

A more just economy and environment in Appalachia will also require massive investment in degraded local infrastructure (for instance, roads, bridges, drinking water, and wastewater systems) and a reversal of rural disinvestment (in, for example, schools, libraries, and community institutions). While much funding in Appalachia has gone to interstate highway development, local infrastructure has often failed to find funding (Eller 2008, Whisnant 1994). Furthermore, as with much rural space in the United States, neoliberalization in Appalachia has meant the hollowing out of public space (Fisher and Smith 2012). Rural libraries have closed due to lack of county funds. Bars, restaurants, music venues, arcades, movie theatres, and drive-ins have shuttered as local income bases have fallen. Increasing funding for libraries, community centers, and youth recreation facilities would alter the terms of life in the coalfields. Crucially, treating poverty as a preventable problem (that is, providing immediate routes out of poverty conditions, such as direct cash assistance) could mean a revolution in public space and public life.

While trends of a declining population and increasing tourist and conservation land uses are clear, the outcomes for those people that remain in the region are not. Massive public investment in environmental remediation, infrastructure, and public life could create the conditions for a more just economy.

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NOTES

1 I use the definition of "Appalachia" according to the Appalachian Regional Commission's map of 420 counties spanning New York to Mississippi, while I generally define the Central Appalachian

region as the area encompassing historically coal-mining counties in northeast Tennessee, southwest Virginia, eastern Kentucky, and West Virginia.

2 I analyzed available grants data, coding the data into categories of investments using federal language (entrepreneurship development, workforce development/training, manufacturing, tourism, healthcare, broadband, trails, food/farming, administrative), with the possibility of three codes per investment (e.g., something could be a tourist-, entrepreneurship-, and food/farming-coded project). I narrowed the geographic scope of the data to former coal-producing counties between Tennessee and West Virginia. I analyzed the 165 grants between 2015 and 2019 (I did not include 2020 data because grant-level data for the \$43 million invested were inaccessible at the time of writing).

3 I do not use names of interviewees to keep their personal and organizational data anonymous as best as possible.

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